Human-made Things in the Bible © United Bible Societies, 2025. Adapted from: The Works of Their Hands: Man-made Things in the Bible, by Ray Pritz © 2009 United Bible Societies. This work is licensed under Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/).

Agriculture and farming

1.1 Agriculture and farming

Yoke

1.1.1 Yoke

References:

Hebrew מוֹט, מוֹטָה (mot, motah) LEV 26:13, ISA 58:6, ISA 58:6, ISA 58:9, JER 27:2, JER 28:10, JER 28:12, JER 28:13, JER 28:13, EZK 30:18, EZK 34:27, NAM 1:13

Hebrew עֹל (ʻol) GEN 27:40, LEV 26:13, NUM 19:2, DEU 21:3, DEU 28:48, 1SA 6:7, 1KI 12:4, 1KI 12:4, 1KI 12:11, 1KI 12:11, 1KI 12:14, 1KI 12:14, 2CH 10:4, 2CH 10:4, 2CH 10:11, 2CH 10:11, 2CH 10:14, ISA 9:3, ISA 10:27, ISA 10:27, ISA 14:25, ISA 47:6, JER 2:20, JER 5:5, JER 27:8, JER 27:11, JER 27:12, JER 28:2, JER 28:4, JER 28:11, JER 28:14, JER 30:8, LAM 1:14, LAM 3:27, EZK 34:27, HOS 11:4

Greek βοοζύγιον (boozugion) SIR 26:7

Greek ἑτεροζυγέω (heterozugeō) 2CO 6:14

Greek κλοιός (kloios) SIR 6:24, SIR 6:29

Greek ζυγός (zugos) MAT 11:29, MAT 11:30, ACT 15:10, GAL 5:1, 1TI 6:1, SIR 21:25, SIR 28:19, SIR 28:20, SIR 28:20, SIR 28:25, SIR 33:27, SIR 40:1, SIR 42:4, SIR 51:26, 1MA 8:18, 1MA 8:31, 1MA 13:41, 3MA 4:9, PSS 7:9, PSS 17:30

Description:

Yoked oxen (© Wikimedia Commons)The yoke was a bar or frame of wood by which two draft animals were joined at the neck so that they could work together effectively in pulling a plow, threshing board, harrow, or wagon. A similar device was used on human beings, but then it was usually a single harness, not the double one used for animals.

Usage:

Slaves in yokes (© Osama Shukir Muhammed Amin FRCP(Glasg), CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons)The yoke was secured to the necks of the animals by means of a kind of collar made of wood, cane, or rope. The center of the yoke was attached, by means of a rope or a bar, to the object to be drawn. The animals pulled together, side by side. A yoke was sometimes placed on a human being who had been taken captive (JER 28:10) or made a slave, to restrict movement or to prevent escape.

Translation:

Where the yoking of draft animals is unknown or unfamiliar, in NUM 19:2 (and similarly for DEU 21:3) translators may follow GNT, which renders the literal text “on which a yoke has never been placed” as “which has never been worked.”

Always in the New Testament and frequently in the Old Testament, “yoke” appears in figurative contexts. It then becomes a symbol of the subjection and servitude of slaves. In such cases (for example, LEV 26:13; ISA 10:27; JER 28:2, JER 28:14; JER 30:8; EZK 34:27; NAM 1:13; ACT 15:10; GAL 5:1; 1TI 6:1), translators may avoid the literal meaning and translate the figurative sense (LEV 26:13: “... I broke the power that held you down ...” [GNT]). Similarly, in SIR 40:1GNT has “... A heavy burden lies on all of us ....”

For the possible reference to a yoke at LAM 5:5, see the comments in A Handbook on Lamentations, page 134.

In SIR 33:27 a yoke is associated with the wearing of a special “harness” or “collar.” This was a device of rope, leather, cane, or wood worn around the neck. The yoke was attached to it. Since it is associated in this verse with control of the animal’s movements, the Italian common language translation (ITCL) renders the word as “reins.” The use of kloios in SIR 6:24; SIR 6:29 is symbolic. In many languages it will be possible to retain the reference to chains and the yoke. However, where a language does not permit such usage, we may say something like “Let all of your actions be ruled by Wisdom” (verse 24) and “If you allow Wisdom to rule you, you will be kept safe, and you will be in control of what happens to you” (verse 29).

Goad

1.1.2 Goad

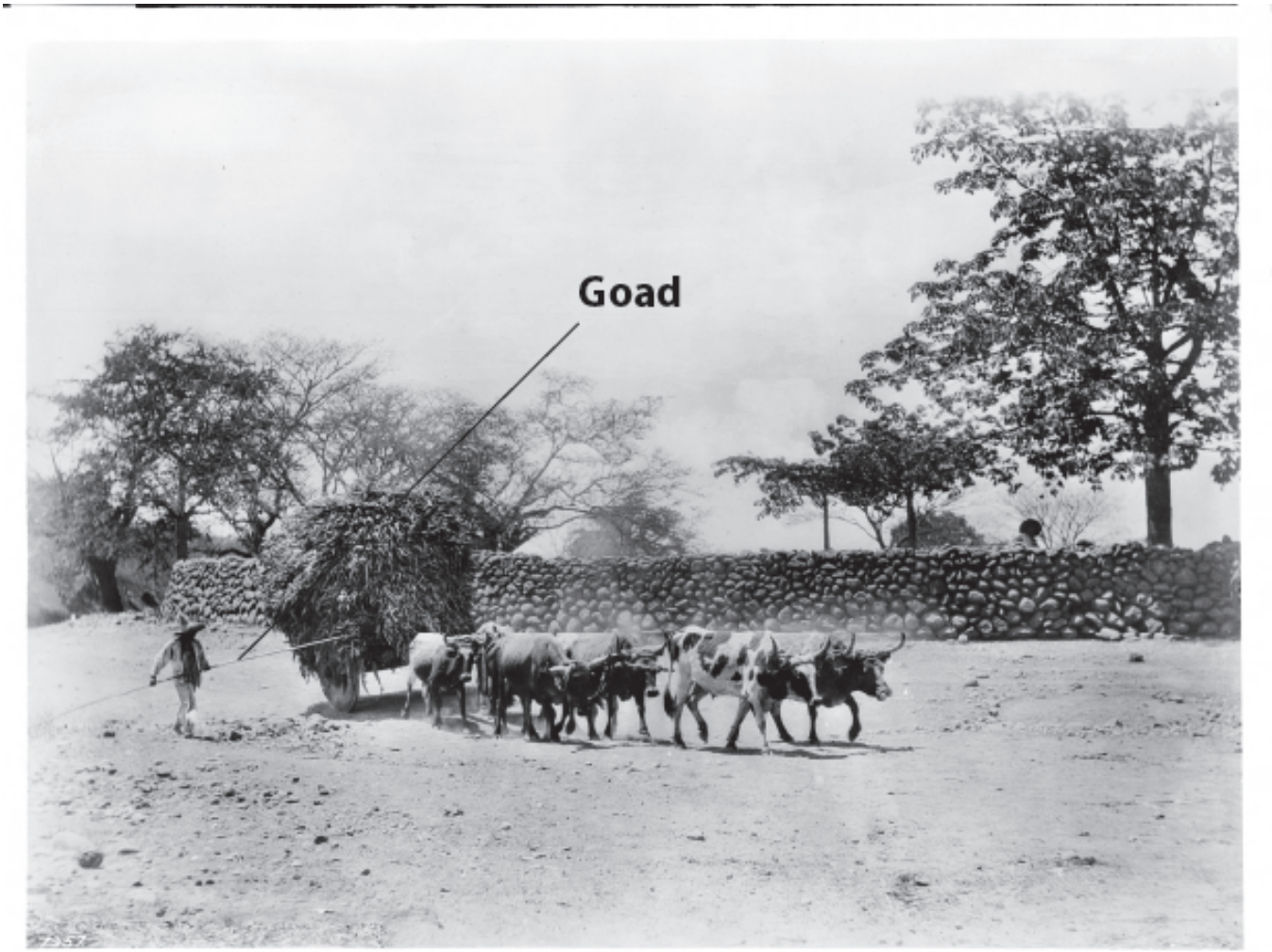
References:

Hebrew דָּרְבָּן (darvan) 1SA 13:21, ECC 12:11

Hebrew מַלְמַד (malmad) JDG 3:31

Greek κέντρον (kentron) ACT 26:14, SIR 38:25, 4MA 14:19, PSS 16:4

Description:



Drawing of a man using a goad to spur on a team of oxen (© Unknown - Wikimedia Commons)The goad was a stick, sometimes tipped with a metal point (darvan), used in driving draft animals or herds of domestic animals, such as sheep. The goad had to be long enough to reach the animal from the driver's position, thus 1–2 meters (3–6 feet).

Usage:

The driver of a cart or other load stuck the point of the goad into the buttocks of an animal that was not pulling hard enough or in the right direction. The pain stimulus caused the animal to move or change direction.

Translation:

Where draft animals are not known, "a goad" in JDG 3:31 may be translated "a pointed stick" or "a rod with a sharp metal point." ECC 12:11 may be expanded as follows: "The sayings of the wise are like the sharp sticks

that shepherds use to guide sheep ...” (GNT; similarly the German common language translation [GECL]) or “The words of experienced men are like goads that stimulate the spirit ...” (French common language translation [FRCL]). Another possible rendering is “The words of wise men are sharp and pointed ...” (Dutch common language translation [DUCL]).

ACT 26:14: This is the only place in the New Testament where the word goad occurs. It is in the phrase “to kick against the goads” (RSV), meaning to react against authority in such a way as to cause harm or suffering to yourself — to hurt yourself by reacting against a person or command. An alternative rendering for the last half of this verse is “Saul, why are you persecuting me? You are hurting yourself by your resistance.”

In SIR 38:25 the activity of the worker is in focus, so it is unnecessary to find a word to translate this object; for example, GNT has “How can a farm hand gain knowledge, when his only ambition is to drive the oxen and make them work ...” Another possibility is “... to get the oxen to move when they want to stop pulling ...?”

Whip, scourge

1.1.3 Whip, scourge

References:

Hebrew שׁוֹט, שֹׁטֵט (shot, shotet) JOS 23:13, 1KI 12:11, 1KI 12:14, 2CH 10:11, 2CH 10:14, JOB 5:21, JOB 9:23, PRO 26:3, ISA 10:26, ISA 28:15, ISA 28:18, NAM 3:2

Greek μαστιγόω, μαστίζω, μάστιξ (mastigoō (verb), mastizō (verb), mastix) MAT 10:17, MAT 20:19, MAT 23:34, MRK 10:34, LUK 18:33, JHN 19:1, ACT 22:24, ACT 22:25, HEB 11:36, HEB 12:6, TOB 13:16, JDT 8:27, WIS 5:11, WIS 12:22, WIS 16:16, SIR 30:14, SIR 23:2, SIR 23:11, SIR 26:6, SIR 28:17, SIR 30:1, SIR 39:28, SIR 40:9, SIR 22:6, 2MA 3:26, 2MA 3:34, 2MA 3:38, 2MA 5:18, 2MA 6:30, 3MA 2:21

Greek φραγέλλιον, φραγελλόω (fragellion, fragelloō (verb)) MAT 27:26, MRK 15:15, JHN 2:15

Latin flagellum 2ES 16:20, 2ES 16:21

Description:

Whip (© Clyde L. Cheney - Wikimedia Commons)The whip was an instrument consisting of either a single or multiple thongs with or without weighted tips on the ends. The thongs were usually leather, and the weighted tips would normally have been made of metal in order to increase the force of the blow and to inflict more severe punishment.

Usage:

Soldier with a whip (© Johnbod, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons)When the whip was used on draft animals, it was intended to cause them to move faster. This was done either by striking the animal with the whip or by flicking the whip so that the end of it made a cracking sound, frightening the animal. The whip used on animals was normally without the weighted tips. When the whip was used on human beings, it was for punishment (see DEU 25:2; DEU 25:3).

Translation:

Where the word “whip” or “scourge” is used figuratively, it will usually be possible to preserve the meaning without keeping the figure. For example, for the literal clause “You shall be hid from the scourge of the tongue” (JOB 5:21 in RSV), GNT has “God will rescue you from slander.”

PRO 26:3: For the literal phrase “A whip for the horse” (RSV), it may be better to use a verb to describe the action; for example, GNT says “You have to whip a horse.”

Muzzle

1.1.4 Muzzle

References:

Hebrew חסם (chasam (verb)) DEU 25:4

Hebrew מַחְסוֹם (machsom) PSA 39:2

Greek φιμός (fimos) SIR 20:29

Greek φιμόω (fimoō (verb)) 1TI 5:18, SUS 1:60, 4MA 1:35

Greek κημόω (kēmoō (verb)) 1CO 9:9

Description and usage:

Muzzled cow used for threshing (Matson Collection, Library of Congress, Public domain)The muzzle was a guard placed over or around the mouth of an animal to prevent it from biting or eating. It was made of rope or leather strips formed into a loose mesh; this allowed the animal to breathe while preventing it from getting anything into its mouth.

Translation:

The two New Testament references are quotations from DEU 25:4 (where 1TI 5:18 follows the Septuagint and 1CO 9:9 uses an equivalent verb). In some languages it may be necessary to use some kind of descriptive equivalent of “to muzzle an ox,” for example, “to tie the mouth of an ox so that it cannot eat” or “to cover the mouth of an ox so that it cannot eat.” In PSA 39:2 the literal text “I will guard my mouth with a muzzle” may be rendered “I will keep silent” (compare GNT “I will not say anything”).

Plow and plowshare

1.1.5 Plow and plowshare

References:

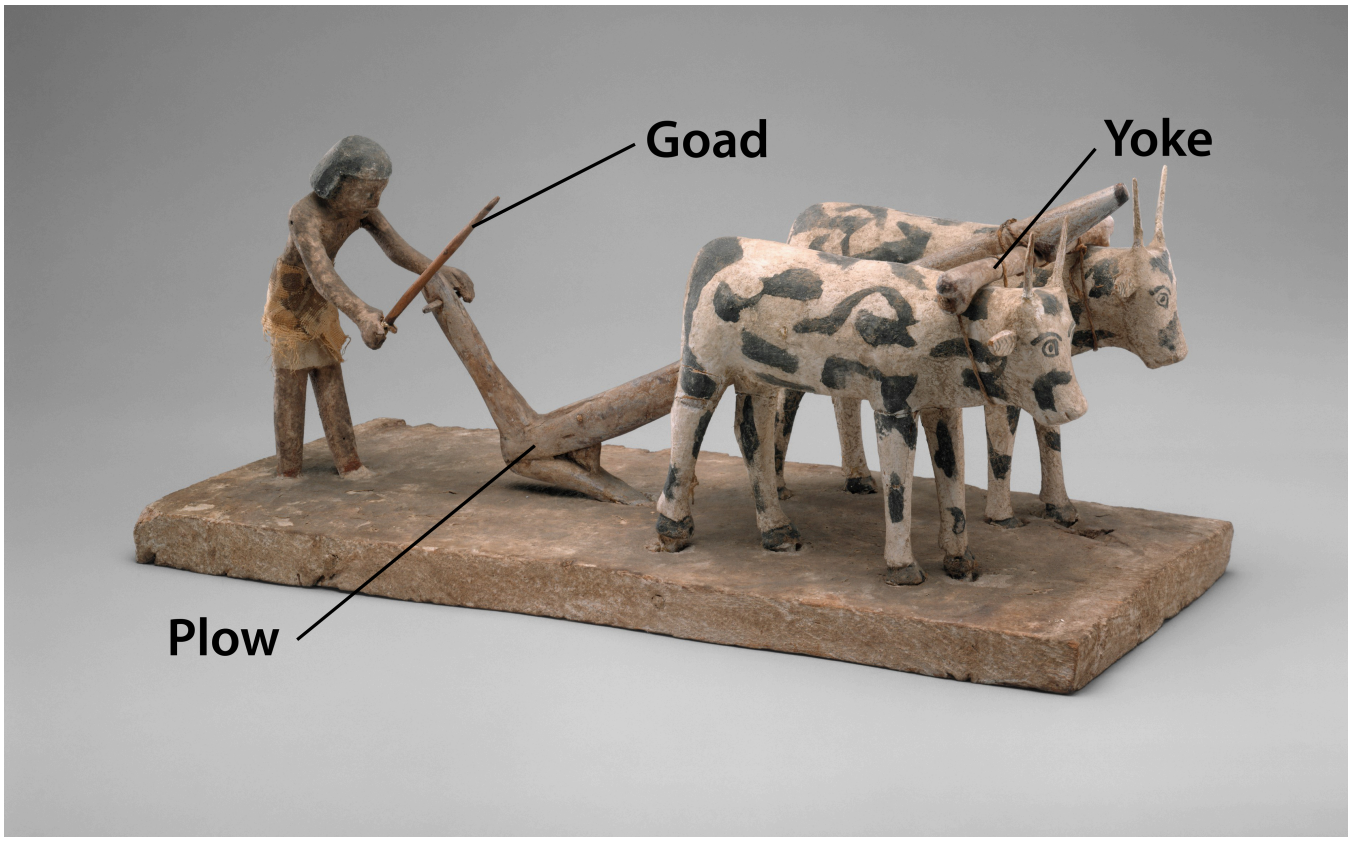
Hebrew אֵת (’eth) 1SA 13:20, 1SA 13:21, ISA 2:4, JOL 4:10, MIC 4:3

Hebrew חרשׁ (charash (verb)) DEU 22:10, JDG 14:18, 1SA 8:12, 1KI 19:19, JOB 1:14, JOB 4:8, PSA 129:3, PSA 129:3, PRO 20:4, ISA 28:24, ISA 28:24, JER 26:18, HOS 10:11, HOS 10:13, AMO 6:12, AMO 9:13, MIC 3:12

Greek ἀροτριάω (arotriaō (verb)) LUK 17:7, 1CO 9:10, 1CO 9:10, SIR 6:19, SIR 7:12

Greek ἄροτρον (arotron) LUK 9:62, SIR 38:25

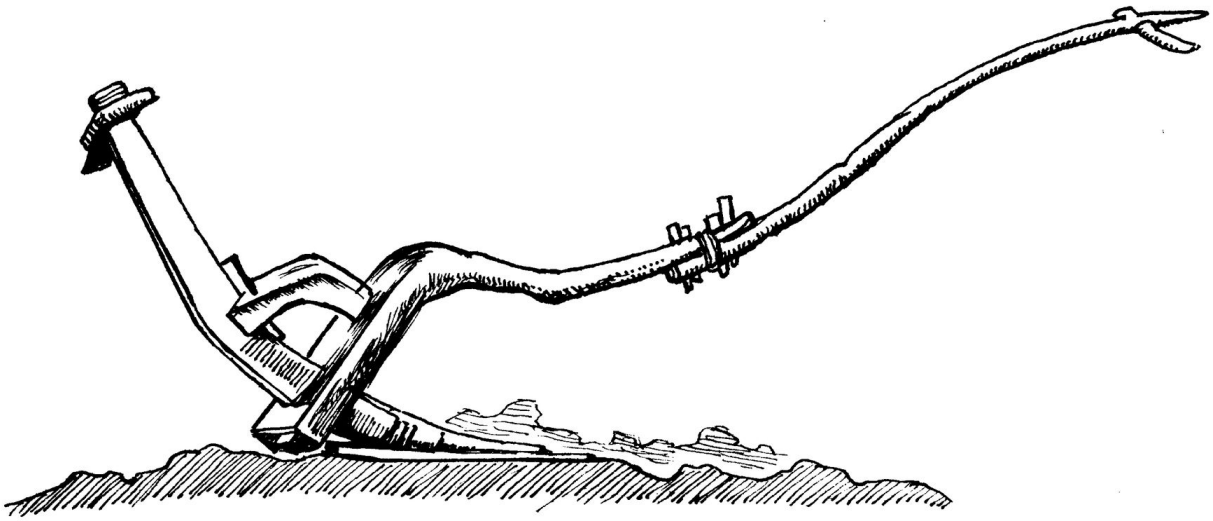
Description:



Egyptian model of a man plowing (Metropolitan Museum of Art, Public domain, MMA)The plow consisted of a flat triangular blade (the “plowshare”) made of hard wood or metal, connected to a handle. In another design the plowshare was a wooden bar covered with a cylindrical, pointed metal sleeve. Ropes or a wooden pole attached to the handle were connected to the yoke and pulled by one or more animals.

Usage:

The plow was used to cut the soil in preparation for the sowing of seed or the planting of seedlings. (The soil might also be plowed again after the seed was scattered, in order to cover the seed and protect it from the birds and from the sun.) The point of the plowshare cut a shallow furrow in the earth. Plows did not turn over the soil but were used simply to break the surface, seldom to a depth of more than 25 centimeters (10 inches). A man could pull the plow, but more often it was pulled by either oxen or donkeys, while a man walked behind and directed the animals and held the plow in its proper line and depth in the soil.



Plow (© Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft, Stuttgart by United Bible Societies)Some have suggested that an ’eth was a kind of sharp instrument that was used to cut the soil prior to the actual plowing.

Translation:

In most parts of the world at least some type of plow is known. Where a plow is unknown, translators may use the name of a tool used for the same kind of agricultural work, such as “hoe.” This will not be possible where the text refers to plowing with animals (for example, DEU 22:10; 1KI 19:19). ’Eth refers to the physical similarity of the plowshare and the sword in ISA 2:4; JOL 4:10; and MIC 4:3. Where plows are unknown, in these passages translators may substitute some other farming tool, which could reasonably be formed from a sword or machete or cutlass.

The Hebrew verb charash is used figuratively in several passages. In JER 26:18 and MIC 3:12 it speaks of the total destruction of Jerusalem, and in JOB 4:8 and HOS 10:13 it expresses the idea that doing an evil deed will bring an evil result. For the figurative use of plowing in PSA 129:3, see A Handbook on Psalms, page 1080.

Sickle

1.1.6 Sickle

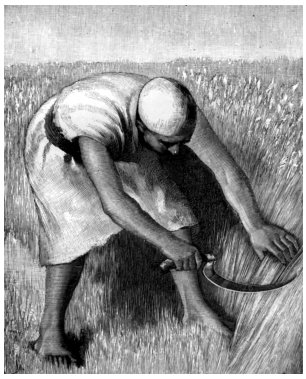
References:

Hebrew חֶרְמֵשׁ (chermesh) DEU 16:9, DEU 23:26

Hebrew מַגָּל (magal) JER 50:16, JOL 4:13

Greek δρέπανον (drepanon) MRK 4:29, REV 14:14, REV 14:15, REV 14:16, REV 14:17, REV 14:18, REV 14:18, REV 14:19

Description:



Man cutting grain with a sickle (The Pictorial New Testament, The Religious Tract Society 1881, Public domain)The sickle was a large, curved knife used for cutting ripe grain. It had a short wooden handle (15–20 centimeters, 6–8 inches).

Usage:

Sickle (© Juan R. Lascorz, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons)The implement was swung in a circular motion close to the ground, cutting off the grass or grain. Using the sickle required bending over in order to cut close to the ground, while the longer handle of the scythe allowed the worker to stand erect (see also 2.15.1 Scythe (chariot weapon)<REALIA:2.15.1>).

Translation:

Where there is no receptor-language term for “sickle,” translators may often use a descriptive phrase, such as “curved knife for cutting grain,” “reaping hook,” or “machete for reaping.” In REV 14:0 the word sickle is used in idiomatic expressions that could be confusing to the reader. For example, in REV 14:15, rather than the literal “Put in your sickle, and reap” (RSV), it may be clearer to say “Use your sickle and reap the harvest” (GNT). The long-handled scythe was unknown in ancient Israel. Where a translator must choose between a short-handled implement and a long-handled one, the former will be more accurate.

Sheaf

1.1.7 Sheaf

References:

Hebrew אֻלְמָה (’alumah) GEN 37:7, GEN 37:7, GEN 37:7, GEN 37:7, PSA 126:6

Hebrew עָמִיר (‘amir) JER 9:21, AMO 2:13, MIC 4:12, ZEC 12:6

Hebrew עמר (‘imer (verb)) PSA 129:7

Hebrew עֹמֶר (‘omer) LEV 23:12, LEV 23:15, DEU 24:19, RUT 2:7, RUT 2:15, JOB 24:10

Greek δράγμα (dragma) JDT 8:3

Description:

Sheaves of grain from the harvest (Jakub Hałun © Wikimedia Commons)The sheaf was a bundle made by binding together the stalks and ears of a crop that had been harvested. The binding was most often done with stalks of the grain itself.

Usage:

Grain was harvested by cutting the stalks low to the ground with a sickle (see 1.1.6 Sickle<REALIA:1.1.6>) or even by pulling them up by hand. The stalks were then gathered into bundles and tied together around the middle, making a sheaf. If the sheaves were not collected immediately, they could be left in the field in a standing position to keep the heads of grain off the damp ground. After the sheaves were collected, they were taken to the threshing floor (see 1.1.8.1 Threshing floor<REALIA:1.1.8.1>).

Translation:

For the word “sheaf,” translators may use a descriptive phrase, such as “bundle of harvested grain.” In some cultures the practice of tying grain into bundles is unknown. Some languages may have to say something like “bunch of grain you tie together.” In some cases it will be necessary to specify what kind of grain is involved. It may be possible to render “sheaf” in a more general sense as “harvest” (so GNT in PSA 126:6; compare GNT in JOB 24:10, where it has “wheat”) or even “grain” (so GNT in AMO 2:13 and MIC 4:12). Another passage where GNT renders “sheaf” in a broader sense is JDT 8:3. The literal RSV text has “as he stood overseeing the men who were binding sheaves in the field,” but GNT says “while in the fields supervising the farm workers.”

The Hebrew words ‘amir and ‘omer actually indicate a heap of many sheaves gathered at the edge of the field before being transported to the threshing floor, so the focus of AMO 2:13 is on the collective weight of the grain.

Threshing and winnowing

1.1.8 Threshing and winnowing

Threshing was the process of separating the grain from the straw by beating it with flails or having animals trample it or dragging a threshing board (see 1.1.8.2 Threshing board, sledge<REALIA:1.1.8.2>) over it

Winnowing consisted of throwing the straw, chaff, grain, and dust into the wind with a wooden winnowing fork (see 1.1.8.3 Winnowing fork<REALIA:1.1.8.3>) or a winnowing basket (see 1.1.8.4 Sieve, winnowing basket<REALIA:1.1.8.4>). The heavier grains would fall back on the threshing floor or into the basket, while the wind would carry away the dust, the chaff, and the straw. The stalks of grain, which had thus been cut and separated from the heads of grain, were used for fodder for the animals.

In the land of Israel the wind normally begins to blow about two o’clock in the afternoon and continues through the evening and into the night. It is important that the wind is not too strong or blustery, and this may explain why the evening was regarded as the best time for winnowing.

The final stage of winnowing consisted of sifting the remaining foreign bodies out of the grain. This was done with a kind of sieve made of a wooden hoop to the bottom of which was fixed a mesh of crisscrossed strips of cane, leather, tree bark, or straw.

Where a technical term for winnowing is lacking, it is sometimes possible to use a descriptive phrase, such as “shaking out the dirt from the grain,” “separating the grain from the chaff,” or “separating the grain from the leaves.”

Threshing floor

1.1.8.1 Threshing floor

References:

Aramaic אִדְּרִי (’idar) DAN 2:35

Hebrew גֹּרֶן (goren) NUM 15:20, NUM 18:27, NUM 18:30, DEU 15:14, DEU 16:13, JDG 6:37, RUT 3:2, RUT 3:3, RUT 3:6, RUT 3:14, 1SA 23:1, 2SA 24:16, 2SA 24:18, 2SA 24:21, 2SA 24:24, 1KI 22:10, 2KI 6:27, 1CH 21:15, 1CH 21:18, 1CH 21:21, 1CH 21:22, 1CH 21:28, 2CH 3:1, 2CH 18:9, JOB 39:12, ISA 21:10, JER 2:25, JER 51:33, HOS 9:1, HOS 9:2, HOS 13:3, JOL 2:24, MIC 4:12

Greek ἅλων (halōn) MAT 3:12, LUK 3:17

Latin area 2ES 4:30, 2ES 4:39, 2ES 9:17

Description:

Threshing floor (© Klearchos Kapoutsis, CC BY 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons)The threshing floor was a level, circular area about 7.5 to 12 meters (25–40 feet) in diameter. It was usually located near the fields where the grain was grown, and if possible it was in an elevated area that was exposed to the breeze (see 1.1.8.3 Winnowing fork<REALIA:1.1.8.3>). Where possible, the threshing floor was located near the village so that the grain could be guarded. The floor was either bedrock or earth that was packed down to make it hard. It was often bordered with rocks to hold in the grain.

Usage:

After grain has been cut, the individual kernels have to be separated from the stalk and the outer seed covering. The cut grain was laid out on the threshing floor. The process of separating the stalks and seed coverings from the kernels could be done by several methods: 1) dragging a threshing sledge (see 1.1.8.2 Threshing board, sledge<REALIA:1.1.8.2>) over the grain, 2) having animals walk back and forth over it, or 3) beating it with some implement.

Translation:

In JER 51:33 and MIC 4:12 the threshing floor symbolizes judgment or punishment. Where threshing is unknown and the meaning would not be clear, it may be made explicit; for example, GNT renders MIC 4:12 b as follows: “They do not realize that they have been gathered together to be punished in the same way that grain is brought in to be threshed.” Compare also the alternative suggested by A Handbook on The Gospel of Matthew for MAT 3:12: “He is ready to judge and separate the good people from the bad, like the farmer who is ready to separate the grain from the chaff with his winnowing fork; he will keep safe the good, like the farmer puts wheat into his granary, and just as the farmer clears his threshing floor of the chaff and burns it in a fire, he will cause the bad people to burn in a fire that never goes out” (page 70).

In MAT 3:12 and LUK 3:17 the meaning of halōn as “threshing floor” forms the basis for the figurative extension of meaning referring to the threshed grain still lying on the threshing floor. This meaning may be made clear by rendering the literal text “he will clear his threshing floor” as “he will thresh out completely all of the grain.” On the other hand, it is possible to interpret halōn in both New Testament references in a literal sense and translate “he will clean up his threshing floor,” that is, by gathering up the grain and getting rid of the straw and chaff.

Threshing board, sledge

1.1.8.2 Threshing board, sledge

References:

Hebrew חָרוּץ (charuts) JOB 41:22, ISA 28:27, ISA 41:15, AMO 1:3

Hebrew מוֹרַג (morag) 2SA 24:22, 1CH 21:23, ISA 41:15

Hebrew עֲגָלָה (‘agalah, ‘eglah) ISA 28:27, ISA 28:28

Description:

Bottom of a threshing board (© Renyrt, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons)The threshing board was a flat wooden surface made of a single piece of wood or several boards attached side-by-side. It measured roughly 1.5 by 1 meter (5 by 3 feet). On one surface a number of small holes were carved, and into these holes hard, sharp stones (flint or basalt) or metal pieces were tightly wedged.

Usage:

Iron threshing board (© CarlosVdeHabsburgo, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons)The threshing board, with the stone side downward, was dragged over the stalks of grain by a draft animal, to which it was attached by ropes. To increase the weight (and the effectiveness) of the implement, the farmer might stand or sit on the board as it was pulled. As the board with its embedded stones passed over the grain, the kernels were separated from the stalks and the seed coverings, while the straw was cut into chaff. See 1.1.8 Threshing and winnowing<REALIA:1.1.8> above.

Translation:

(Image generated by ChatGPT using OpenAI technology) ISA 28:27; ISA 28:28 uses several terms for instruments that performed basically the same function. The ‘agalah /‘eglah was probably a sledge with sharp discs and a seat on top. The point of the agricultural reference in verse 27 is that the seeds mentioned, dill and cumin, are too small to be threshed in the same way as larger grains such as wheat and barley. The Hebrew word charuts probably indicates a threshing board with iron spikes instead of stones. The Hebrew word ’ofan in verse 27 refers to the wheel of a cart (see 8.3 Wheel<REALIA:8.3>).

AMO 1:3 speaks of “threshing sledges of iron” (RSV). This does not mean that the platform was made of iron but rather that iron spikes were protruding from the wooden platform instead of the usual stones. This language in AMO 1:3 is probably figurative, and where that sense would be lost, the last half of this verse may be expanded to say “because they destroyed the people of Gilead like someone threshes grain with iron-studded sledges.” Or it may be rendered nonfiguratively as in GNT, which reads “They treated the people of Gilead with savage cruelty.”

Winnowing fork

1.1.8.3 Winnowing fork

References:

Hebrew זרה (zarah (verb)) RUT 3:2, PRO 20:8, PRO 20:26, ISA 30:24, ISA 41:16, JER 4:11, JER 15:7, JER 51:2

Hebrew מִזְרֶה (mizreh) ISA 30:24, JER 15:7

Hebrew רַחַת (rachath) ISA 30:24

Greek λικμάω (likmaō (verb)) SIR 5:9

Greek πτύον (ptuon) MAT 3:12, LUK 3:17

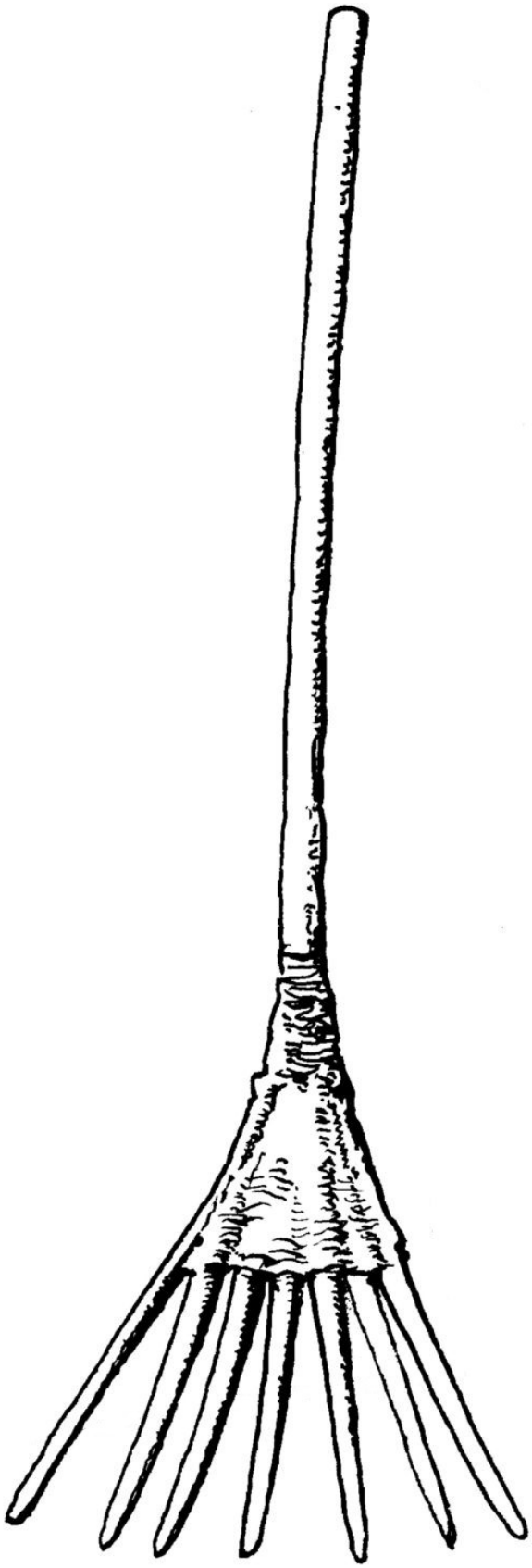
Description:

(Image generated by ChatGPT using OpenAI technology)The winnowing fork was a wooden fork-like implement, with five to seven prongs, for throwing threshed grain into the air so that the wind might separate the straw and chaff from the grain.

Usage:

See 1.1.8 Threshing and winnowing<REALIA:1.1.8>.

Translation:



A winnowing fork is used in separating grain from chaff (© Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft, Stuttgart by United Bible Societies)Where there is no receptor-language term for a winnowing fork, translators may choose a descriptive phrase, for example, “a tool for throwing threshed grain into the air in order to let the chaff blow away.”

The Hebrew verb zarah means literally “to scatter.” It refers to a variety of operations in Scripture, including the process of winnowing.

Translation:

Wooden Spade, possibly used in winnowing (watercolor and graphite on paper, Archie Thompson, 1938) (National Gallery of Art, CC0, via Wikimedia Commons)The Hebrew word rachath appears only once in Scripture at ISA 30:24, where its meaning is uncertain. It probably refers to a wooden implement with a long, flat blade attached to a long handle, similar to a spade but made of wood. The verse names two objects for performing the different stages of winnowing. The point of the verse is that even the food given to the animals will have been thoroughly prepared. Some translations eliminate the need to translate an implement by following the Septuagint; for example, CEV has “Even the oxen and donkeys that plow your fields will be fed the finest grain.”

In SIR 5:9 the activity of winnowing is used in a proverb. The literal text of the New Revised Standard Version (NRSV) says “Do not winnow in every wind, or follow every path,” but GNT restructures (and reverses the order of) verses 9 and 10 to give the meaning of the proverb: “Don’t try to please everyone or agree with everything people say.”

Sieve, winnowing basket

1.1.8.4 Sieve, winnowing basket

References:

Hebrew כְּבָרָה (kvarah) AMO 9:9

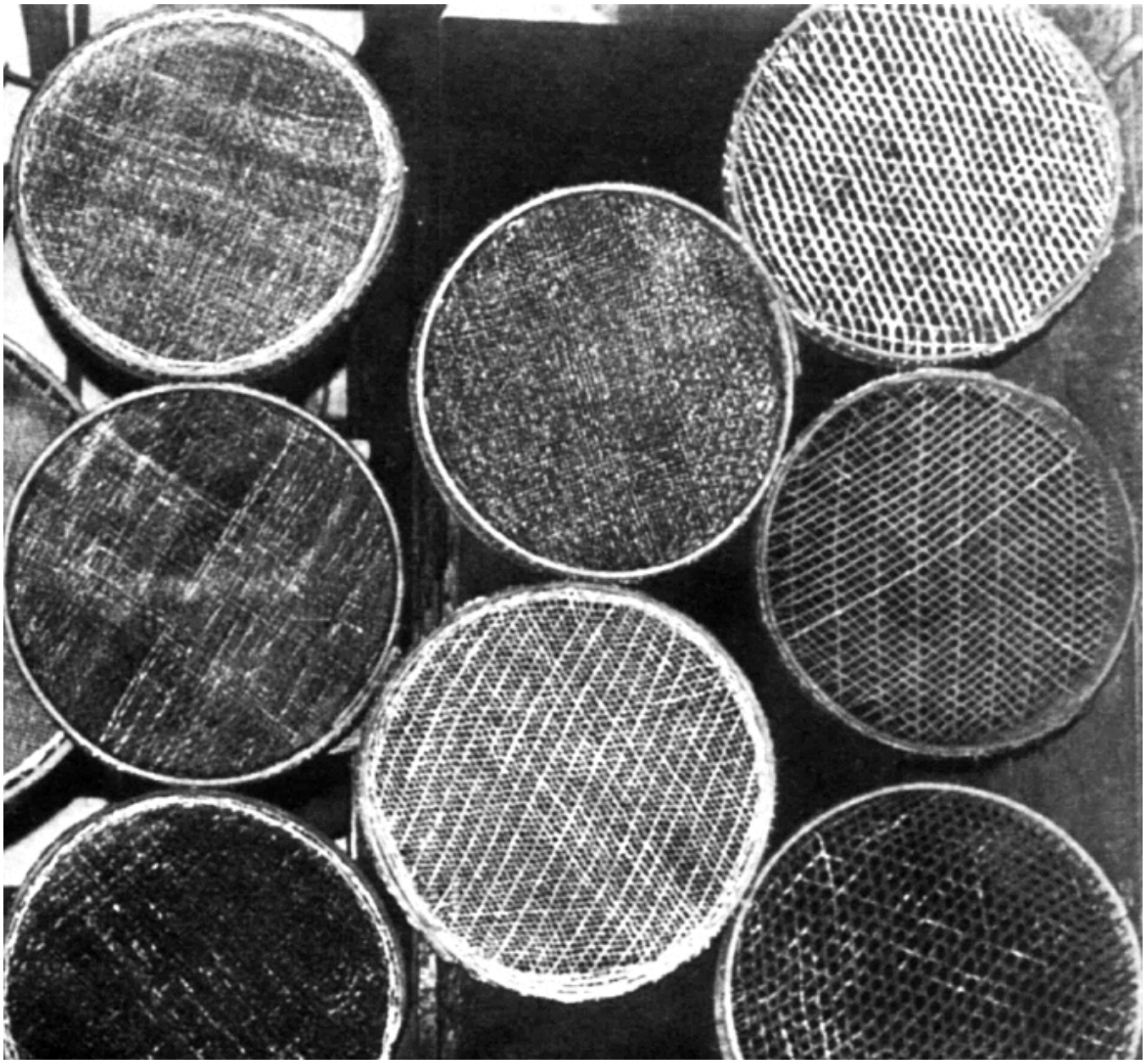
Hebrew נָפָה (nafah) ISA 30:28

Hebrew נוף (nuf) ISA 30:28

Greek κόσκινον (koskinon) SIR 27:4

Greek σινιάζω (siniazō (verb)) LUK 22:31

Description:



Winnowing baskets or sieves for separating grain and chaff (© Israel Government Press Office)The second stage of winnowing was carried out with a shallow, flat circular kind of sieve. This sieve had a mesh bottom made of straw, cord, strips of bark, or reed. The fineness of the mesh varied according to the purpose for which it was intended.

Translation:

Some languages may have a different word for an instrument that sifts dry things, like grains, and one that allows liquids to pass through but keeps the solids. In all of the references above it is the former instrument that is intended.

ISA 30:28: This verse comes in a context that describes the punishment and destruction of the nations, which is compared to shaking something back and forth in a sieve in the third line of this verse: “to sift the nations with the sieve of destruction” (NRSV). GECL expands the four Hebrew words in this line to “He shakes the nations in his sieve and throws them out like worthless chaff.” In some languages even such an expansion will not give

sufficient understanding, and it may be best to drop the image of the sieve. GNT drops both the picture of the sieve and the following one of putting a bit in the mouth of an animal and combines them into “It [the wind] sweeps nations to destruction and puts an end to their evil plans.” Almost all translations consulted attempt to maintain the image of sifting. The Hebrew word nafah may indicate a finer sieve, more appropriate for something like flour.

Woman sifting grain with a sieve (© Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft, Stuttgart by United Bible Societies) AMO 9:9: The Hebrew word for sieve here probably refers to a coarse type of sieve in which stones are kept while the grain passes through. The same type of sieve was also used by bricklayers, who separated the larger stones from the fine sand that they used for mortar. The picture used here could therefore be based on either grain or sand. It does not really matter which picture the translator chooses, since the important point is that not one of the stones gets through the sieve. They will all be caught and then discarded.

God is commanding the enemy to treat Israel like this; none of the sinners among the people of Israel will escape punishment, just as no stone gets through the sieve. It may be possible to translate “I will shake/sift the people of Israel like someone shakes sand [or, grain] in a sieve, through which not a single stone falls to the ground. I will shake/sift them to remove the bad people from among them.”

While the physical object “sieve” is not mentioned in LUK 22:31, the act of sifting is. Some languages will find it more natural to speak of the instrument with which the action is performed; compare ITCL “... to pass you all through a sieve, as is done with grain to separate it.”

Iron tools

1.1.9 Iron tools

1SA 13:20; 1SA 13:21 presents a special problem to the translator, with a list of between five and seven different implements, depending on how the somewhat obscure Hebrew is interpreted. The following list is according to the translation order of RSV:

“Plowshare” (macharesheth): Some commentators have suggested that this first word in the list is a general term, meaning “tools for working the soil.” What follow would then be separate instruments, including the machareshah, which appears in Hebrew with exactly the same consonants, made different only by the vowel points. This interpretation is, however, far from certain.

“Mattock” (’eth): This possibly means “plowshare” (see 1.1.5 Plow and plowshare<REALIA:1.1.5>), although ancient mattocks (a kind of hoe) have been found.

“Axe” (qardom): This is translated also by the Septuagint as “axe” (axinē in Greek). More precisely, it was probably an axe-like implement with a blade that was perpendicular to the handle. The implement served as a kind of hoe for loosening the soil or like an adze for shaping wood (see 1.1.9.3 Axe, adze<REALIA:1.1.9.3>).

“Sickle” (machareshah): Here again RSV has followed the Septuagint in translating “sickle” (see 1.1.6 Sickle<REALIA:1.1.6>). However, another ancient translator renders the word as a kind of small garden hoe used for loosening and weeding the soil, and this interpretation is preferred here (see 1.1.9.1 Hoe<REALIA:1.1.9.1>).

“The charge was a pim” (haptsirah fim): See the discussion on pimPim<REALIA:11.1.3>

“A third of a shekel” (shlosh qilshon): Here again the meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain. Many translations see this as a second (and lower) price for sharpening two of the smaller implements. This translation assumes that letters have been reversed in the Hebrew text (see Hebrew Old Testament Text Project [HOTTP]). A number of commentators and translators prefer to see here another kind of farming implement, a kind of three-pronged rake or fork on a wooden handle. If it was a rake, it was used to scrape together loose cuttings. However, more likely it was a fork, which would need its points sharpened from time to time. Such a fork was used to lift piles of cuttings.

“Goad” (darvan): See 1.1.2 Goad<REALIA:1.1.2>.

The general point of this passage is that the Israelites were forced to take their blunt farming implements to the Philistines for sharpening. Where a language lacks equivalent words for several of the implements, a translation may express the idea with a general statement by rendering verses 20–21 as follows: “The Israelites had to go to the Philistines to have their iron farming tools sharpened. The price varied according to the tool.” Another possible model is “... to sharpen their iron farming tools which had become blunted. The price varied according to the tool.” See also the comments on this passage in A Handbook on the First and Second Books of Samuel, pages 267–269.

Hoe

1.1.9.1 Hoe

References:

Hebrew מַחֲרֵשָׁה (machareshah) 1SA 13:20, 1SA 13:20, 1SA 13:21

Hebrew מַעְדֵּר (ma'der) ISA 7:25

Description:

Man using a hoe (Metropolitan Museum of Art, CC0, MMA)The hoe was a flat metal blade, 10–20 centimeters (4–8 inches) wide, mounted on a wooden handle with the blade at a right angle to the handle. The illustration to the left shows the blade without a handle.

Usage:

This implement was used to loosen the soil, especially for weeding.

Translation:

Hoe blade (Roman) (© Giovanni Dall'Orto, Attribution, via Wikimedia Commons)See the note on 1SA 13:20; 1SA 13:21 at 1.1.9 Iron tools<REALIA:1.1.9>.

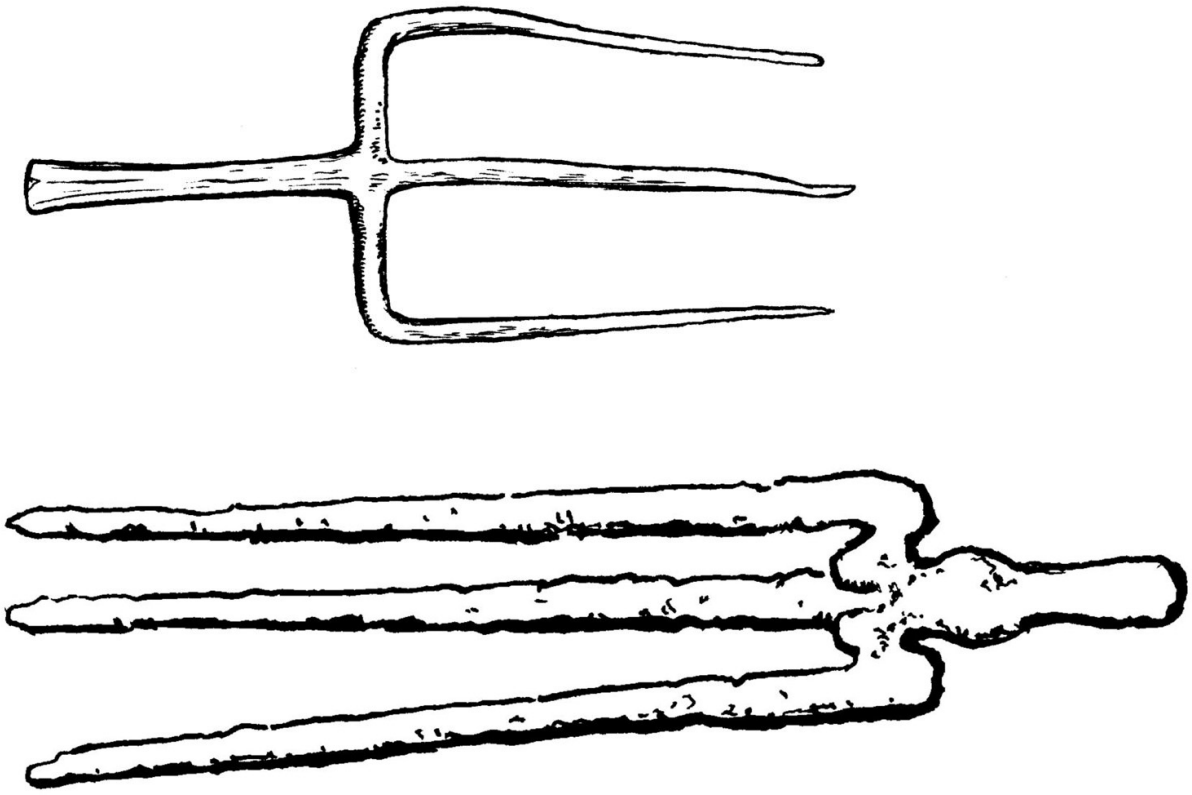
Fork

1.1.9.2 Fork

Reference:

Hebrew שְׁלֹשׁ קִלְשׁוֹן (shlosh qilshon) 1SA 13:21

Description:



Three-pronged fork heads (© Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft, Stuttgart by United Bible Societies)The fork was an iron head consisting of two or three pointed prongs attached to the end of a wooden handle approximately 1–1.3 meters (3–4 feet) in length.

Usage:

The fork was used by farmers and field workers to lift piles of cuttings.

Translation:

See the discussion on 1SA 13:20; 1SA 13:21 above.

Axe, adze

1.1.9.3 Axe, adze

References:

Hebrew בַּרְזֶל (barzel) DEU 19:5, 2KI 6:5, 2KI 6:6, ISA 10:34

Hebrew גַּרְזֶן (garzen) DEU 19:5, DEU 20:19, 1KI 6:7, ISA 10:15

Hebrew מַעֲצָד (ma'atsad) JER 10:3

Hebrew קַרְדֹּם (qardom) JDG 9:48, 1SA 13:20, 1SA 13:21, PSA 74:5, JER 46:22

Greek ἀξίνη (axinē) MAT 3:10, LUK 3:9

Greek πέλεκυς (pelekus) LJE 1:13

Description:

Adze with wooden handle (Metropolitan Museum of Art, CC0, via Wikimedia Commons)The axe or adze was an instrument with a metal, sharp-edged head attached to a wooden handle about the length of a man's arm. The handle was usually wedged tightly into a hole opposite the sharp blade, and it could be held more firmly in place by cords bound around the head and handle. The blade of the axe (garzen) was parallel to the handle, while the blade of the adze (qardom) was perpendicular to the handle.

Usage:

1
5
2
6
3
7
4
8

Various bronze socketed axe and adze heads, Syria and Iran (2nd-1st millenia BCE, San Antonio Museum of Art, Near Eastern collection) (© Zereshk, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons)It was used to cut down trees and woody plants as well as to chop them into smaller pieces. It could also serve as a carpenter's tool for shaping wood.

Translation:

It is likely that the axe mentioned in LJE 1:13 is a kind of weapon rather than a work tool. While the general form of the implement was the same, some languages may make a distinction between the work tool and the weapon. It is also possible to translate the first half of this verse more generally; for example, "Sometimes they are holding weapons."

Pruning knife

1.1.9.4 Pruning knife

References:

Hebrew מַזְמֵרָה (mazmerah) ISA 2:4, ISA 18:5, JOL 4:10, MIC 4:3

Description:

Pruning hook (Lax1, Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons)The pruning knife was a knife or metal blade, sometimes attached to a long wooden handle.

Usage:

The pruning process involved cutting away or cutting back unproductive branches so they could produce better.

Translation:

All of the references, except ISA 18:5, are to making spears into pruning knives or vice versa. Where metal plows and pruning knives are not used as agricultural tools, some adjustment in this figure will be necessary. The essential point is that instruments of war and bloodshed will be replaced by instruments of peace and prosperity (or the opposite in JOL 4:10). If iron instruments are not used in an area, it may not be possible to keep the idea that the weapons themselves are made into agricultural tools. In such a case, a translator can simply say that people will destroy their weapons and make tools for farming instead.

Wine press

1.1.10 Wine press

References:

Hebrew גַּת (gath) JDG 6:11, NEH 13:15, ISA 63:2, LAM 1:15, JOL 4:13

Hebrew יֶקֶב (yeqev) NUM 18:27, NUM 18:30, DEU 15:14, DEU 16:13, JDG 7:25, 2KI 6:27, JOB 24:11, PRO 3:10, ISA 5:2, ISA 16:10, JER 48:33, HOS 9:2, JOL 2:24, JOL 4:13, HAG 2:16, ZEC 14:10

Hebrew פּוּרָה (purah) ISA 63:3

Greek ληνός (lēnos) MAT 21:33, REV 14:19, REV 14:20, REV 14:20, REV 19:15, SIR 33:17

Greek ὑπολήνιον (hupolēnion) MRK 12:1

The Greek word hupolēnion in MRK 12:1 refers to the wine trough/vat.

Description and usage:

Man in a winepress (© James Emery - Wikimedia Commons)The wine press was a place for pressing out the juice of grapes for the making of wine (see 9.1 Wine<REALIA:9.1>), vinegar, and grape honey. Ancient wine presses consisted of large treading floors on which the grapes were trampled in order to extract the juice. Depending on the topography, a wine press floor could be larger and shallower than the one depicted in the illustration below. Beneath the wine press floor was placed (or cut out of the rock) a trough or vat into which flowed the grape juice that had just been pressed out.

Translation:

The Hebrew word gath usually indicates the treading floor or the entire installation, while yeqev is the collecting vat.

A descriptive equivalent of “wine press” may be “place where the juice of grapes was squeezed out” or “... pressed out” (similarly Parole de Vie [PV] in MRK 12:1). The Spanish common language translation (SPCL) has “place where wine is made” (JDG 6:11). For “wine trough,” translators may use a descriptive phrase, such as “place where the juice of the grapes was collected.”

The Hebrew word purah may refer to a measure of pressed juice or the act of pressing out the juice in a wine press. In ISA 63:3 most translations render it “wine press.” For the first line of this verse the New Jewish Publication Society Version (NJPSV) is more accurate with “I trod out a vintage alone.” Good models are GNT “I have trampled the nations like grapes” and CEV “I alone stomped the grapes!”

The Greek word lēnos means a depression, hole, trough, or pit. The operation of pressing grapes involved more than one such depression; there was one (in the land of Israel it was a flat surface) in which the grapes were placed and tread, and one or more into which the juice flowed. Lēnos can refer to either of these, and it will usually be sufficient to render it something like “pit to crush the grapes in” (CEV; MAT 21:33).

Lēnos is the word used in MAT 21:33. In the parallel passage in MRK 12:1 a different Greek word is used (hupolēnion), a word that means a pit which lies below the lēnos, that is, a “collection pit” into which the juice flowed from the upper surface where the grapes were crushed. translations render both words the same, usually “wine press” or its equivalent. Some translations (Traduction œcuménique de la Bible [TOB], NJB, NRSV, New International Version [NIV], New American Standard Bible [NASB]) use a different word or expression in Mark; for example, NASB has “vat under the wine press.”

Watchtower

1.1.11 Watchtower

References:

Hebrew מִגְדָּל (migdal) GEN 35:21, 2CH 26:10, ISA 5:2, MIC 4:8

Greek πύργος (purgos) MAT 21:33, MRK 12:1, LUK 14:28

Description and usage:

Description and usage:

The watchtower was a structure made of stone, sometimes round but more often rectangular. It was normally built on a high place in or near a vineyard. It stood 2–5 meters (6–16 feet) high and was mounted by a ladder or steps. During the grape harvest, it was the custom for the owner of a vineyard or one of his family members or servants to spend the night on the watchtower to guard against animals or thieves who might try to steal the grapes. Similar towers could also be built to watch over other property, such as sheep and goats.

Translation:

English uses basically the same expression to describe this structure in a farmer's field and a lookout point on a city wall (see 3.13.3.3 Watchtower, tower<REALIA:3.13.3.3>). In some languages, however, the two structures may have very different terms. In a few verses (for example, 1CH 27:25; 2CH 26:10; SIR 37:14), it is not entirely clear from the context which type of tower is intended; in GEN 35:21 and MIC 4:8 the reference may be to either one, or it may even be a place name.

Some translators may want to use a descriptive phrase for "watchtower," for example, "tower to keep watch over the vineyard" (PV; MAT 21:33).

Irrigation channel, canal

1.1.12 Irrigation channel, canal

References:

Hebrew יְאֹר (y'or) EXO 7:19, EXO 8:1

Hebrew נָהָר (nahar) ISA 19:6

Greek διῶρυξ (diōrux) SIR 24:30, SIR 24:31

Greek ὑδραγωγός (udragōgos) SIR 24:30

Description and usage:

Description and usage:

An irrigation channel that runs down from Wadi Kelt to Jericho (© Bukvoed, CC BY 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons)The irrigation canal was a small channel cut into the rock or dug into the ground to transfer water from a larger source such as a river into a cultivated plot of ground. The reference in SIR 24:30 gives a good description of its function: “an irrigation canal bringing water from a river into a garden” (GNT). Gardens could be watered by a system of smaller channels running off a larger channel and feeding into all parts of the garden, using gravity to deliver the water.

Translation:

The Hebrew word y’or normally refers to the Nile River. However, most translations agree that in EXO 7:19 and EXO 8:5 (1) it means “irrigation canal.” Similarly, the Hebrew word nahar normally means “river,” but in ISA 19:6, where it is plural in Hebrew, most translation render it “canals” (RSV) or “channels” (NJPSV).